Civic Transparency Toolkit

User Guide

Local news your community can trust, powered by AI

Version 1.8

March 2026

MIT Open Source License

1. What Is This?

The Civic Transparency Toolkit is a free, open-source desktop application that helps anyone produce trustworthy local news. It scans public records, city agendas, school board actions, meeting transcripts, and local news sites, then writes sourced stories in plain language your neighbors can read and share.

It runs on your own computer, sends nothing to any server except the Anthropic Claude API (which does the AI work), and saves every result as files you control.

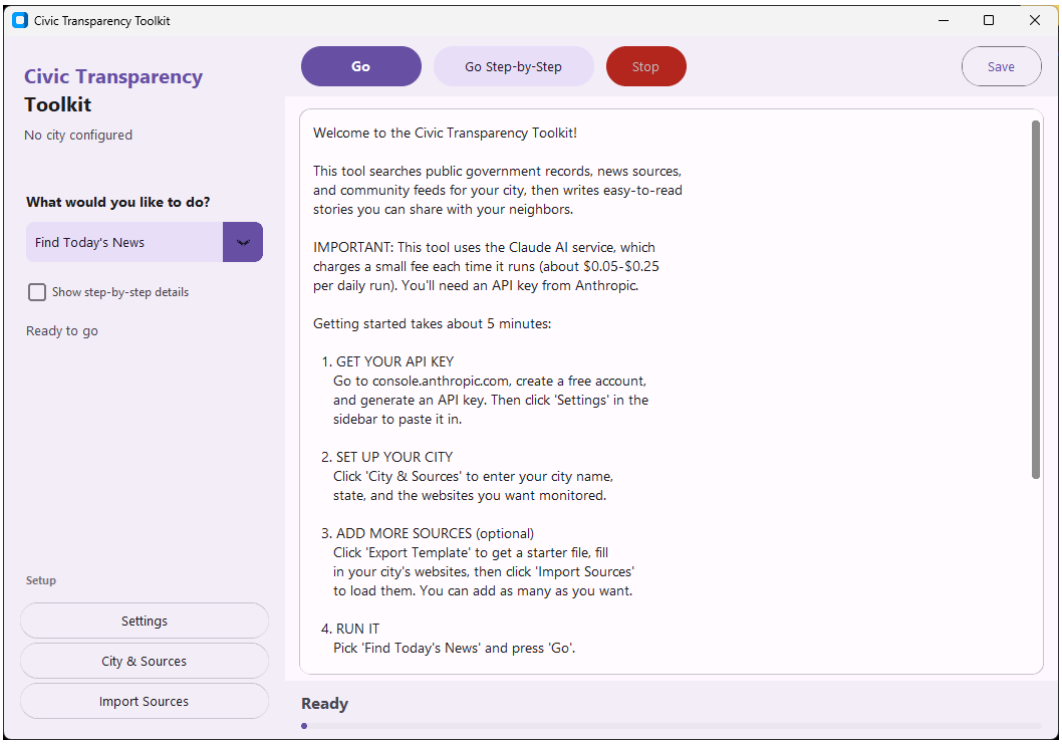

Figure 1 — Welcome screen on first launch

2. Getting Started

Getting started takes about five minutes. You need three things: the toolkit itself, an Anthropic API key, and basic information about your city.

2.1 Install

Unzip the distribution folder anywhere. Double-click **CivicTransparencyToolkit.exe** to launch. No installation required.

2.2 First Launch

The first time you open the toolkit, a "Before You Start" dialog explains the API key requirement and pricing. Read it and click OK.

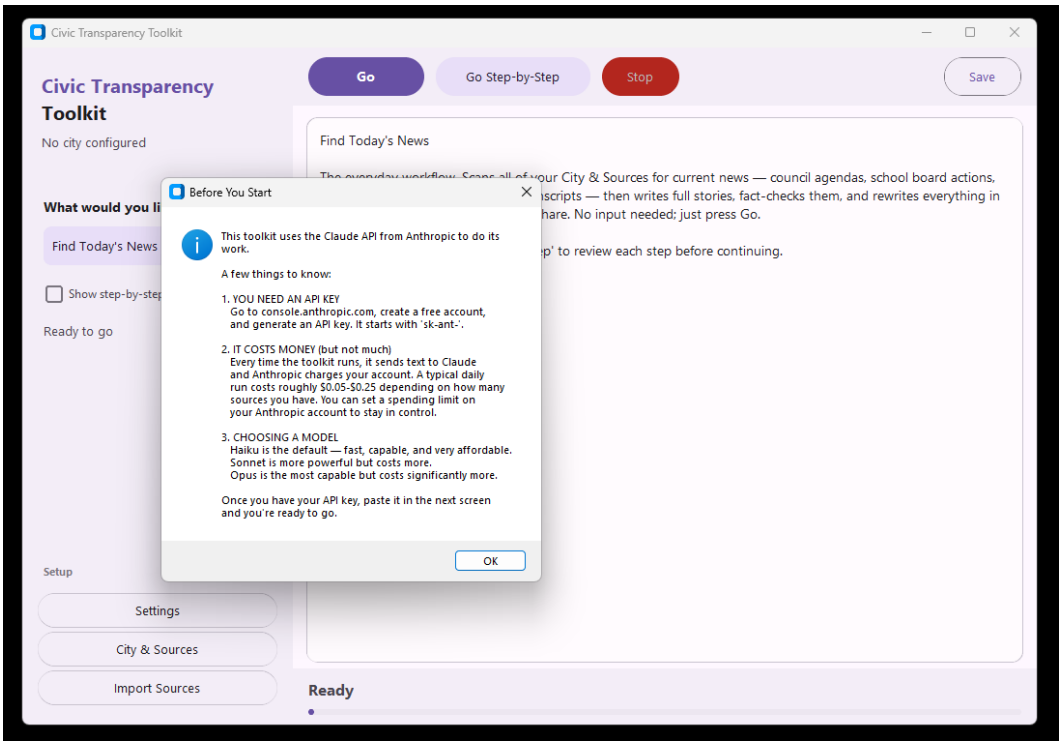

Figure 2 — Before You Start dialog

2.3 Enter Your API Key

Click **Settings** in the sidebar. Paste your API key from **console.anthropic.com** into the Claude API Key field. Choose a model (Haiku is the default — fast and affordable). Optionally set an output folder. Click **Save Settings**.

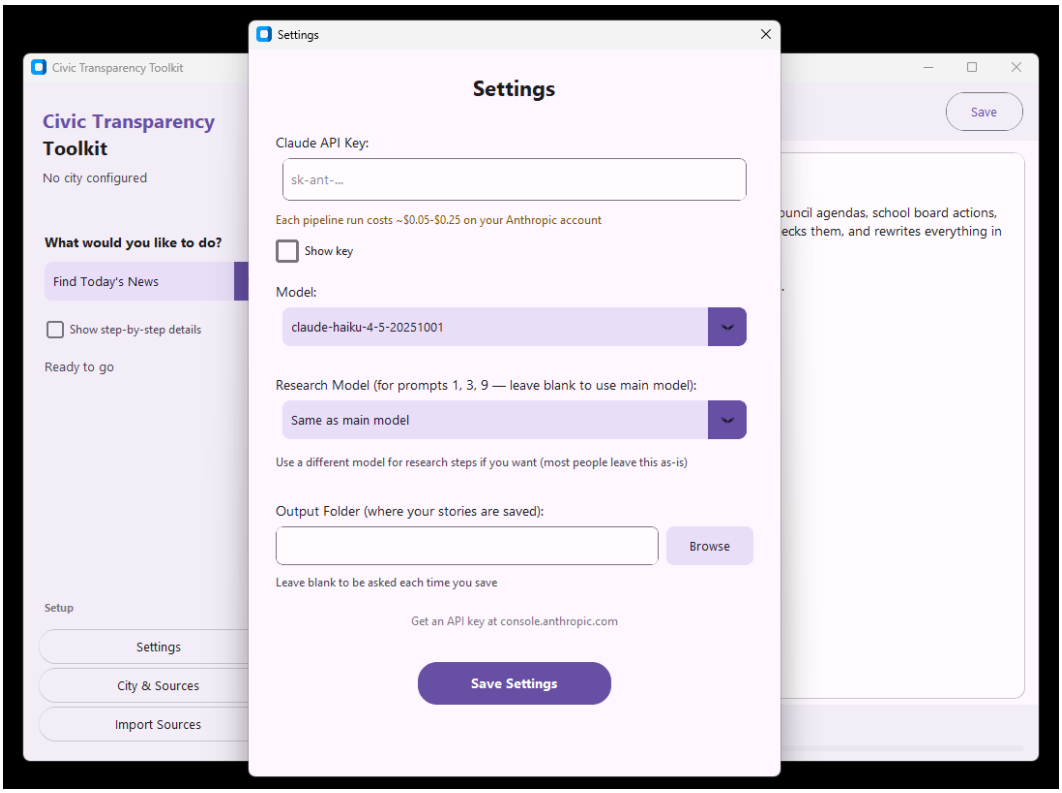

Figure 3 — Settings panel: API key, model selection, output folder

> **Tip:** Set a spending limit on your Anthropic account to stay in control of costs. A typical daily run costs $0.05–$0.25.

2.4 Configure Your City

Click **City & Sources** in the sidebar. Fill in your city name, state, and as many fields as you can — city agenda portal URL, school district, local media outlet, YouTube channel, and so on. The more you provide, the better the toolkit's research.

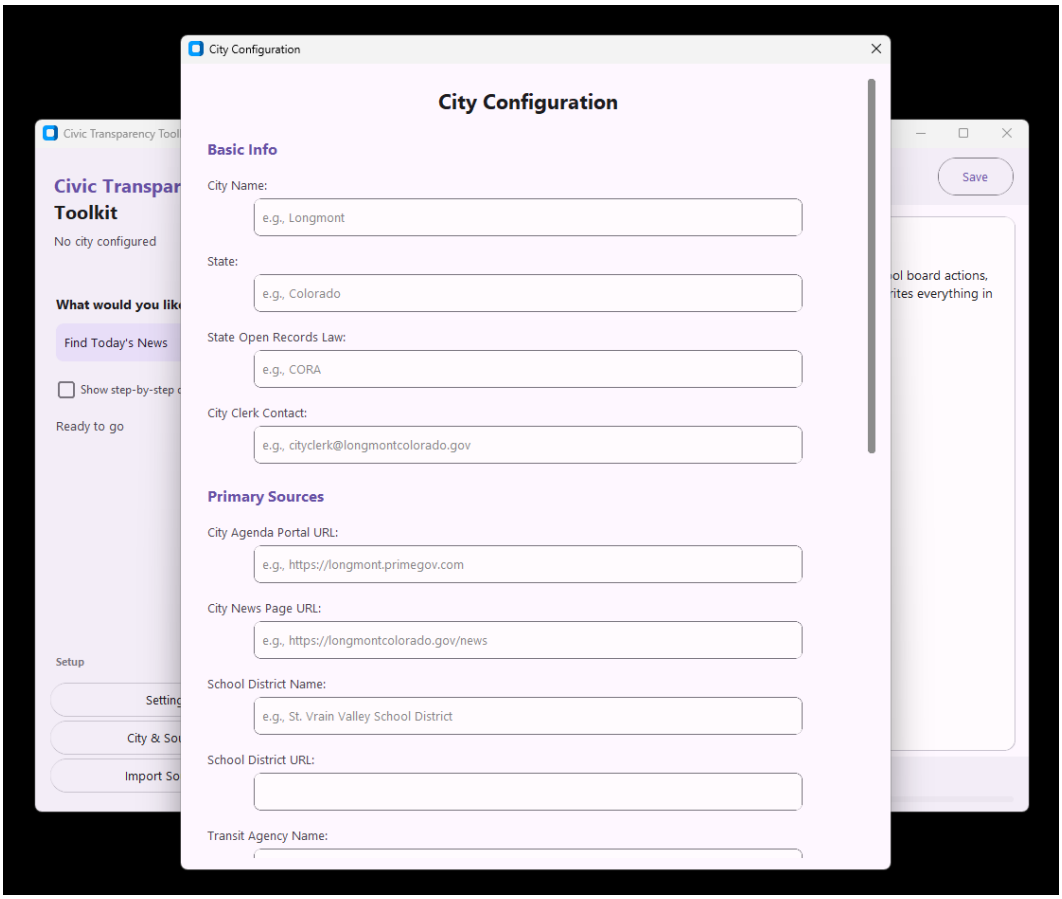

Figure 4 — City Configuration: basic info and primary sources

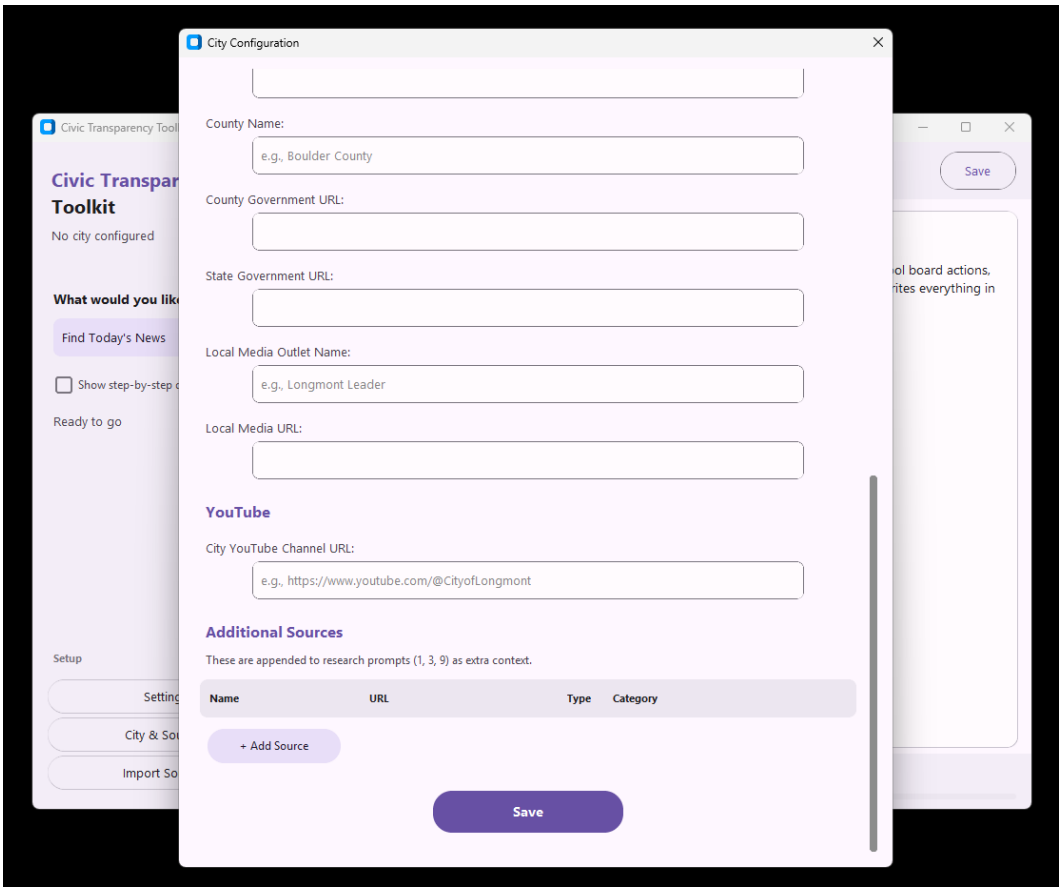

Figure 5 — City Configuration: county, state, local media, YouTube, and additional sources

Tip: You can also import sources from a CSV file using the Import Sources button in the sidebar. An example file (Real World Example Sources List.csv) is included.

3. The Interface

The main window has four areas:

Left Sidebar — The workflow dropdown ("What would you like to do?"), the step-by-step toggle, and the three Setup buttons: Settings, City & Sources, and Import Sources.

Top Bar — Go (starts the run), Go Step-by-Step (pauses between stages so you can review), Stop (cancels), and Save (exports results to files).

Main Panel — Shows the current workflow's description, and then displays live output as each stage runs. Some workflows also show an input field above the main panel for your topic or story text.

Status Bar — At the bottom, shows "Ready," the current stage name, or a progress indicator.

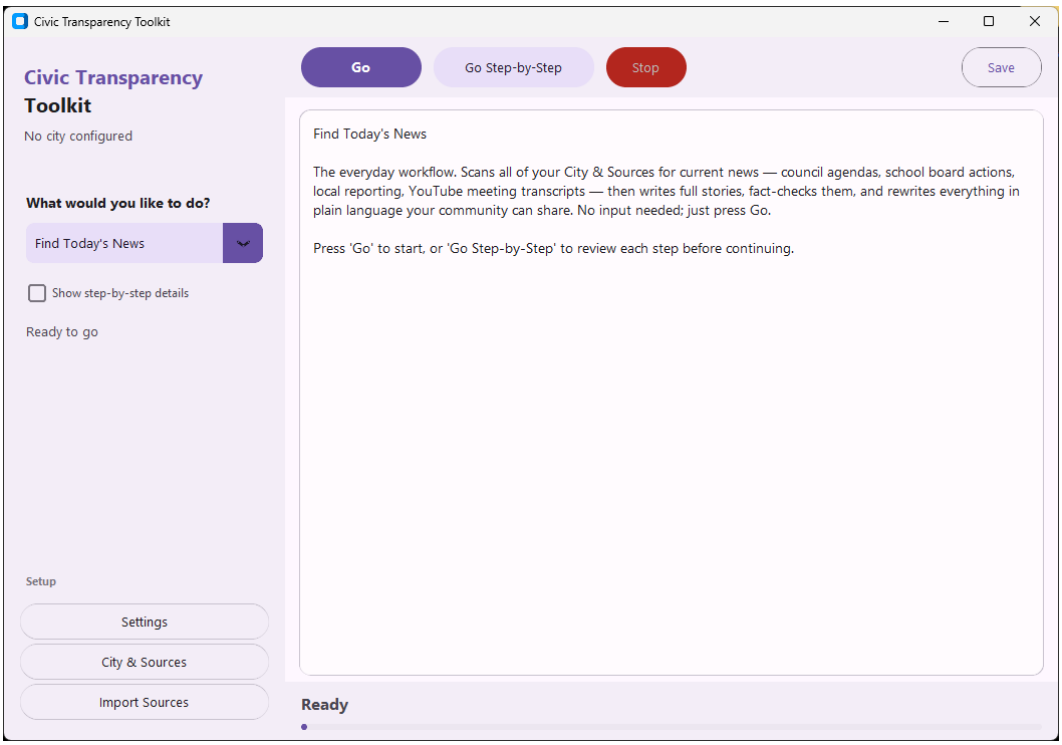

Figure 6 — Main interface: Find Today's News workflow selected

4. The Six Workflows

Choose a workflow from the dropdown on the left sidebar. Each one chains together different tools (called "stages") in a specific order. Here's what each one does and when to use it.

4.1 Find Today's News

Stages: 1 → 2 → 5 → 7

The everyday workflow. Scans all of your City & Sources for current news — council agendas, school board actions, local reporting, YouTube meeting transcripts — then writes full stories, fact-checks them, and rewrites everything in plain language your community can share. No input needed; just press Go.

Best for: Daily use. Run it every morning to see what's happening in your city.

4.2 Write a Story

Stages: 9 → 5

Type a topic in the field above the main panel and the toolkit will research it from scratch — searching public records and news sources — then write a complete story with source citations, followed by a fact-check. Be specific: "What's happening with the new housing development on Hover Street?" works better than "Tell me about housing."

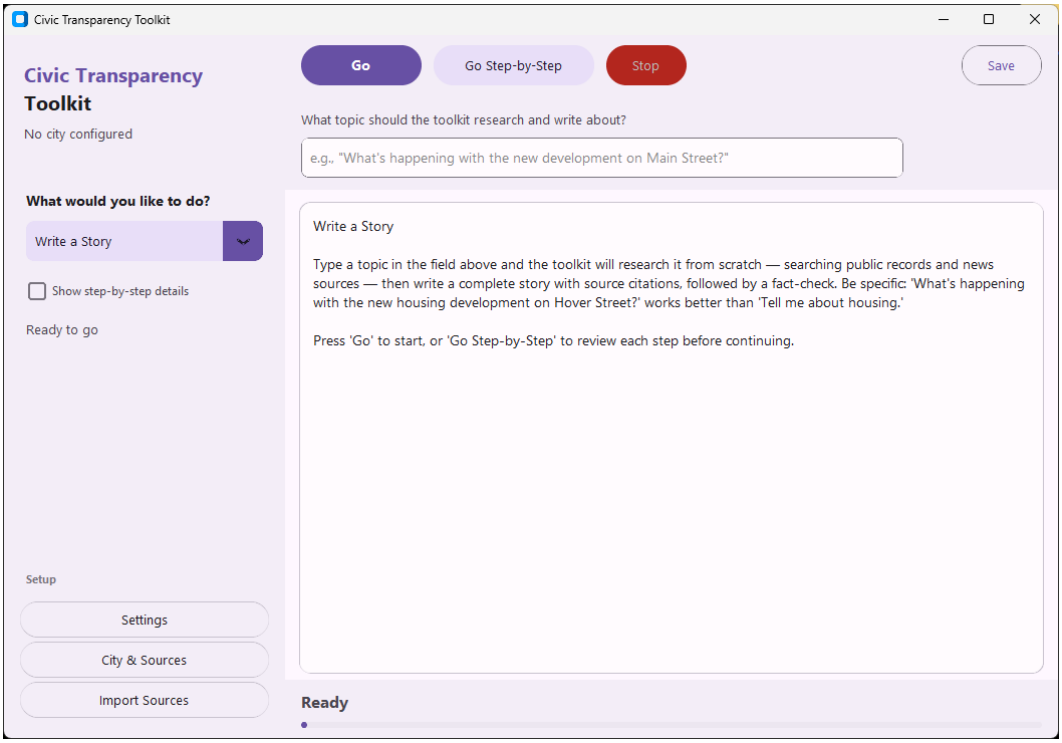

Figure 7 — Write a Story: topic input field above the main panel

Best for: Covering a specific issue, following up on a lead, or answering a question from a community member.

4.3 Polish Existing Stories

Stages: 2 → 7 → 5

Already have story drafts? Paste them into the text box above the main panel. The toolkit will expand them with additional context and sourcing, rewrite them in plain shareable language, and run a fact-check. Good for cleaning up output from a previous run or polishing your own writing.

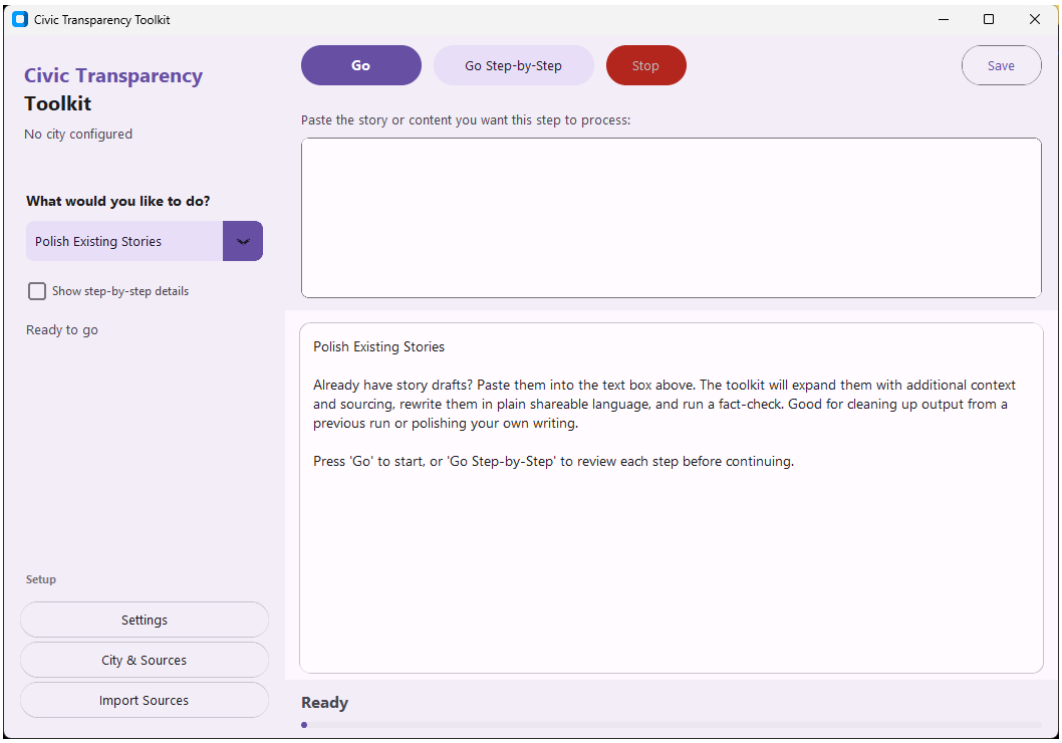

Figure 8 — Polish Existing Stories: paste area for your draft text

Best for: Refining raw output from a previous run, improving your own drafts, or preparing content for publication.

4.4 Dig Deeper

Stages: 3 → 4

Looks for hidden patterns and connections your regular news sources aren't covering. Reads between the lines of public records, community forums, and meeting transcripts to find leads worth investigating. The output is investigative signals — questions worth asking — not finished stories. Press Go to scan your sources.

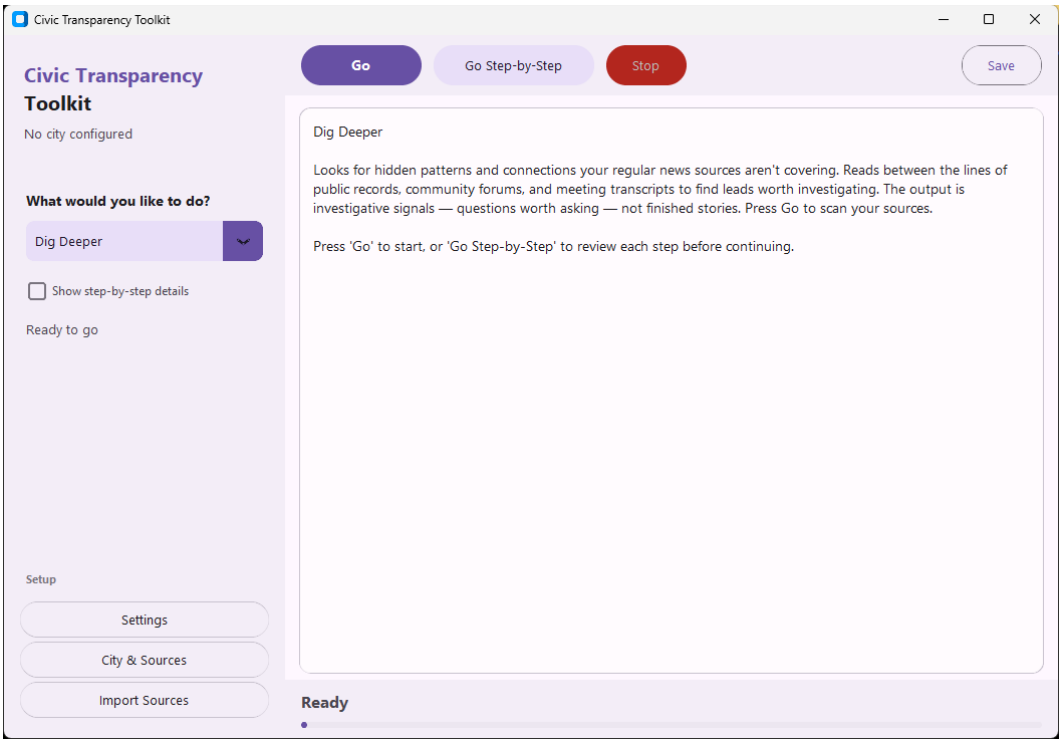

Figure 9 — Dig Deeper workflow

Best for: Investigative journalism. Finding things the official channels aren't talking about.

4.5 Investigate Hidden Stories

Stages: 3 → 9 → 5

The full investigation pipeline. Finds hidden patterns in your sources, then independently researches each one and writes complete, sourced stories — followed by a fact-check that catches errors before anything reaches your community. This is the most thorough workflow and produces the most detailed output. No input needed; press Go to start.

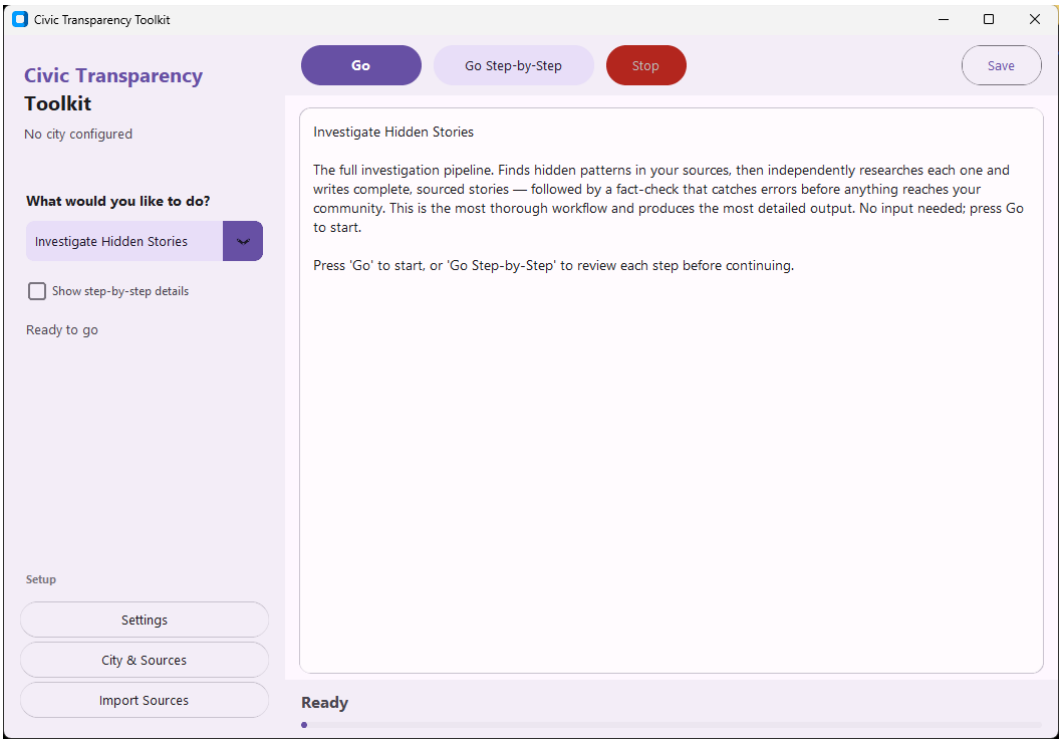

Figure 10 — Investigate Hidden Stories workflow

Best for: When you have time for deep investigation and want complete, publishable stories on hidden issues.

4.6 Run a Single Step

Stages: You choose one

Run any one of the nine tools by itself. Pick a step from the list — the toolkit will show you what input it needs (if any) and what it does. Useful for running the fact-checker on a story you wrote yourself, looking up a legal question with First Amendment Counsel, or experimenting with individual tools.

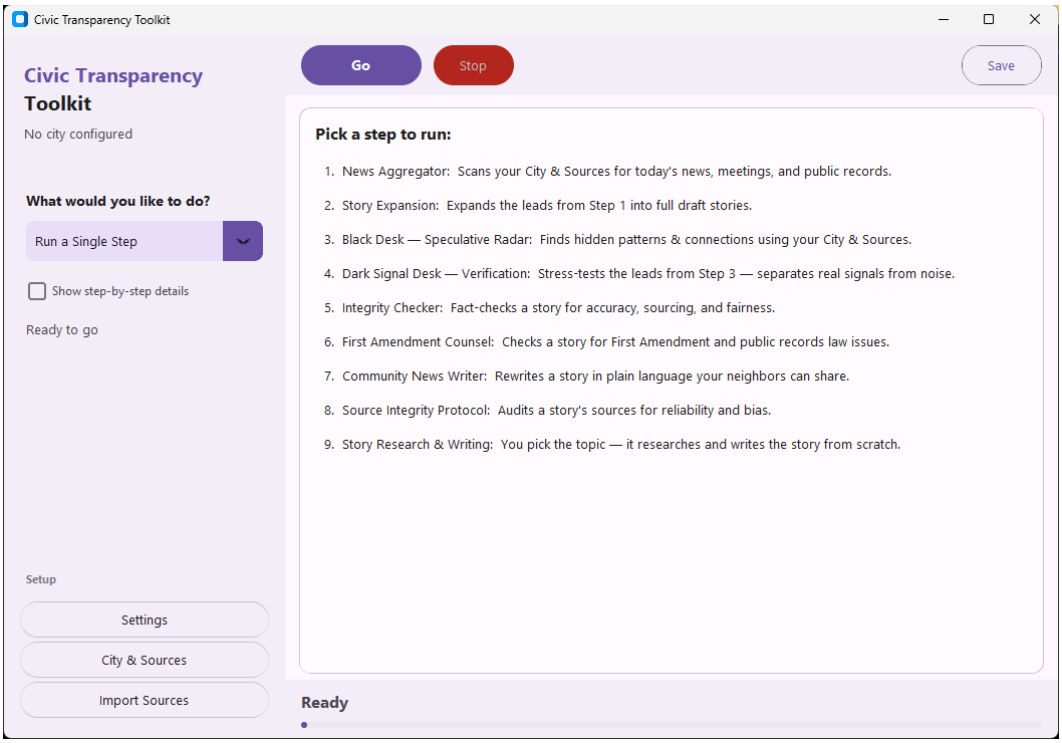

Figure 11 — Run a Single Step: choose from all nine tools

Best for: Power users. Running one specific tool on your own content, or learning what each stage does.

5. The Nine Tools (Stages)

Each workflow chains together some of these nine tools. Here is every tool, what it does, and what it needs as input.

#	Tool Name	What It Does	Input
1	News Aggregator	Scans your City & Sources for today's news, meetings, and public records.	None (uses your sources)
2	Story Expansion	Expands leads from Step 1 into full draft stories with context.	Raw leads or notes
3	Black Desk — Speculative Radar	Finds hidden patterns and connections across your sources.	None (uses your sources)
4	Dark Signal Desk — Verification	Stress-tests Step 3's leads. Separates real signals from noise.	Output from Step 3
5	Integrity Checker	Fact-checks a story for accuracy, sourcing, and fairness.	A story to check
6	First Amendment Counsel	Reviews a story for First Amendment and public records law issues.	A story to review
7	Community News Writer	Rewrites a story in plain language your neighbors can share.	A story to rewrite
8	Source Integrity Protocol	Audits a story's sources for reliability and bias.	A story with sources
9	Story Research & Writing	You pick the topic — it researches and writes the story from scratch.	A topic or question

6. Understanding the Output

6.1 Live Display

As each stage runs, its output streams live into the main panel. Stages are separated by horizontal rules and bold headers showing the tool name.

6.2 Step-by-Step Mode

Check **Show step-by-step details** in the sidebar, then press **Go Step-by-Step**. The toolkit pauses after each stage so you can review the output before continuing. Useful for learning what each tool does and for quality-checking intermediate results.

6.3 Saving Output

Click **Save** after a run completes. The toolkit writes each stage's output to a separate text file in your chosen output folder. Files are named with the date, workflow, and stage number — for example: *2026-03-13_daily-production_stage1.txt*.

> **Tip:** If you set a default Output Folder in Settings, the toolkit saves there automatically. Otherwise it asks you each time.

7. Managing Costs

The toolkit uses the Anthropic Claude API, which charges per token (roughly per word). Here's what typical runs cost:

Workflow	Typical Cost	Notes
Find Today's News	$0.05–$0.25	Depends on how many sources you have
Write a Story	$0.02–$0.10	Depends on topic complexity
Polish Existing Stories	$0.03–$0.15	Depends on story length
Dig Deeper	$0.03–$0.10	Two stages only
Investigate Hidden Stories	$0.05–$0.25	Most thorough, most expensive
Run a Single Step	$0.01–$0.05	One stage only

Model choice matters: Haiku is the default and by far the cheapest. Sonnet is more capable but costs more. Opus is the most powerful but costs significantly more. Most users should stick with Haiku for daily runs.

> **Tip:** Set a monthly spending limit on your Anthropic account at console.anthropic.com. You can always raise it later.

8. Customizing for Your City

The toolkit is designed to be adapted to any city. The City & Sources configuration drives everything — the more complete it is, the better the output.

8.1 Primary Sources

These are the core fields: city agenda portal, city news page, school district, and YouTube channel. Fill in as many as you can.

8.2 Additional Sources

The Additional Sources table at the bottom of the City Configuration screen lets you add any number of extra URLs — community forums, county records, neighborhood blogs, and so on. Each one gets a name, URL, type, and category.

8.3 Importing Sources from CSV

For bulk setup, use **Import Sources** in the sidebar. The CSV format uses four columns: Name, URL, Type, and Category. An example file (Real World Example Sources List.csv) is included in the distribution.

> **Tip:** Start with the example CSV, replace the Longmont sources with your city's equivalents, and import. You can always add more later.

9. Tips & Best Practices

Run daily. The News Aggregator (Step 1) works best when run every day. It looks for new content since the last scan.

Be specific with topics. When using Write a Story, a specific question produces much better results than a vague topic. “What’s happening with the Hover Street housing development?” beats “Tell me about housing.”

Always fact-check. The Integrity Checker (Step 5) is your safety net. Every workflow that produces stories includes it. If you’re running a single step, run Step 5 afterward.

Use Step-by-Step mode to learn. When you’re first getting started, use Go Step-by-Step to see what each stage produces. It helps you understand the pipeline and catch issues early.

Save your output. Click Save after every run. The text files are your archive and can be pasted into newsletters, websites, or social media.

Add more sources over time. The more sources you configure, the more comprehensive the output. Start with the basics and add community forums, county records, and neighborhood blogs as you find them.

10. Troubleshooting

10.1 "API key not set"

Click **Settings** and paste your API key. It should start with **sk-ant-**.

10.2 "Rate limit" or "429" errors

The toolkit automatically retries with escalating waits. If it persists, wait a few minutes and try again, or switch to a less busy model.

10.3 "No city configured"

Click **City & Sources** and fill in at least your city name and state.

10.4 Empty or thin results

Add more sources. The toolkit can only find what’s at the URLs you give it. More sources means richer output.

10.5 Output looks garbled

Make sure you’re running the latest version. If a run was interrupted, try again — partial results sometimes look odd.

11. Running from Source

The full source code is included in the source/ folder. To run from source instead of the .exe:

1. Install Python 3.9 or later from python.org
2. Open a terminal in the source/ folder
3. Run: **pip install -r requirements.txt**
4. Run: **python main.py**

To rebuild the .exe, run build.bat. It handles dependencies, PyInstaller, and distribution packaging automatically.

12. License & Credits

The Civic Transparency Toolkit is released under the MIT License. You are free to use, modify, and distribute it for any purpose.

It uses the Anthropic Claude API for AI processing. Anthropic's usage policies apply to API calls. The toolkit itself stores no data remotely — everything stays on your computer.

Built with Python, CustomTkinter, and the Anthropic SDK. Source code, issues, and contributions at the project's GitHub repository.

— End of Guide —